



QUICK GUIDE

What is a biomarker?

Understand a word that's now part of your story.



The definition

A biomarker is a measurable feature of your tumor — a protein, a gene, or a molecule — that tells your medical team how your cancer behaves and which treatments are most likely to work for you. Think of it as a **fingerprint**: every tumor leaves its own, and that fingerprint helps choose a treatment tailored to your case, not a generic protocol.



Where it comes from

Biomarkers are almost always studied in the same tissue used to diagnose you: the biopsy or surgical specimen your pathologist reviewed. The results appear in your **pathology report** — sometimes on the same page as the diagnosis, sometimes in a separate report that arrives later.



Why it matters

Not every cancer with the same name is treated the same way. Two people with breast cancer may need different treatments if their biomarkers differ. This is called **precision medicine**: treatment is tailored to your tumor's characteristics, not just its location.



Names you might see in your report

HER2, PD-L1, hormone receptors (ER/PR), KRAS, BRCA. Each one tells a different part of your tumor's story — we explain them one by one in the Understand Your Diagnosis guides. For now, you just need to know they exist.



For you

Understanding these words doesn't change your treatment — it changes how you experience the process: with more clarity around terms that used to sound like distant science.

Clinical scope notice: the content of this material is educational and does not replace medical consultation, nor does it constitute a diagnosis or treatment. It strengthens —not replaces— your relationship with your treating team.